

BONUS 1 OF 3

Quick Stitch Guide

The stitches that appear most in patterns, explained one by one.

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SECTION 1

Before you start

What you need in your hands and which words CrochetLib uses.

Crochet is a small set of stitches repeated in different orders. Learn these few well and every pattern in CrochetLib opens up.

What you need

- A crochet hook and a ball of smooth, light-colored yarn (light colors show the stitches best).
- Scissors and a yarn needle for weaving in ends.
- A stitch marker. A safety pin or a scrap of yarn works too.

US terms, not UK terms

The same stitch has different names in the US and the UK. **Every CrochetLib pattern uses US terms.** If you have a pattern from another source, check which one it uses before you start.

US TERM (CROCHETLIB)	SHORT FORM	UK TERM FOR THE SAME STITCH
Slip stitch	sl st	Slip stitch
Single crochet	sc	Double crochet
Half double crochet	hdc	Half treble crochet
Double crochet	dc	Treble crochet

Common mix-up

A UK “double crochet” is a US single crochet. If your work looks much shorter or taller than the photo, check the terms first.

SECTION 2

Slip knot, chain and slip stitch

The three moves that start almost every project.

Slip knot

- 1 Make a loop of yarn, with the tail end lying behind the working yarn.
- 2 Reach through the loop, grab the working yarn and pull up a new loop.
- 3 Put that new loop on your hook and pull the tail gently to tighten it. It should slide, not grip.

Chain (ch)

- 1 Yarn over: wrap the yarn over the hook from back to front.
- 2 Pull the yarn through the loop that is on your hook. That is one chain.
- 3 Repeat. Do not count the loop that is on the hook.

Slip stitch (sl st)

- 1 Put the hook into the stitch or chain the pattern says.
- 2 Yarn over and pull the yarn through the stitch and through the loop on the hook in one motion.
- 3 Use it to join rounds, move across a row without adding height, and make tiny finishing edges.

Tip

Keep your chains loose. If the starting chain is tight, the whole piece will pull in at the bottom.

SECTION 3

Single crochet (sc)

The stitch behind almost every amigurumi, bag and basket.

- 1 Put the hook into the next stitch (under both top loops, unless the pattern says otherwise).
- 2 Yarn over and pull up a loop. You now have 2 loops on the hook.
- 3 Yarn over and pull through both loops. That is one sc.

Single crochet makes a dense, firm fabric. That is why we use it for toys and baskets: it holds its shape and hides the stuffing.

Turning chain

When you crochet in rows, you make a chain at the start of a row to reach the height of the next row. For sc rows that is 1 chain, and it does not count as a stitch. Each CrochetLib pattern tells you if a turning chain counts, so follow the pattern.

SECTION 4

Half double (hdc) and double crochet (dc)

Taller stitches for softer, faster fabric.

Half double crochet (hdc)

- 1 Yarn over, then put the hook into the next stitch.
- 2 Yarn over and pull up a loop. You now have 3 loops on the hook.
- 3 Yarn over and pull through all 3 loops.

Double crochet (dc)

- 1 Yarn over, then put the hook into the next stitch.
- 2 Yarn over and pull up a loop. You now have 3 loops on the hook.
- 3 Yarn over and pull through 2 loops. You now have 2 loops on the hook.
- 4 Yarn over and pull through the last 2 loops. That is one dc.

STITCH	HEIGHT	TURNING CHAIN (USUAL)	BEST FOR
sc	Shortest	ch 1, does not count	Toys, baskets, bags
hdc	Medium	ch 2, patterns say if it counts	Scarves, hats, blankets
dc	Tallest	ch 3, often counts as the first dc	Granny squares, throws, lacy mesh

SECTION 5

Increase, decrease and the magic ring

How amigurumi grows, shrinks and closes.

Increase (inc)

Work 2 single crochet in the same stitch. A pattern that says *inc in each st around* means you do this in every stitch of the round.

Decrease (dec)

- 1 Put the hook into the next stitch and pull up a loop (2 loops on the hook).
- 2 Put the hook into the following stitch and pull up a loop (3 loops on the hook).
- 3 Yarn over and pull through all 3 loops. Two stitches have become one.

Invisible decrease

For a smoother look on toys, put the hook only into the front loop of each of the next 2 stitches, yarn over, pull through both front loops, then yarn over and pull through the 2 loops on the hook.

Magic ring (MR)

- 1 Make a loop with a tail about 6 inches (15 cm) long, and hold the crossing point between finger and thumb.
- 2 Put the hook through the loop, yarn over with the working yarn and pull it up.
- 3 Chain 1 to lock it. This chain does not count as a stitch.
- 4 Work the number of stitches the pattern asks for (usually 6 sc) into the ring, going over both the ring and the tail.
- 5 Pull the tail to close the ring tight, then continue with round 2.

SECTION 6

Working in the round

Spiral rounds, joined rounds and closing a piece.

Spiral rounds (no joining)

Most CrochetLib toys are worked in a spiral: you go around and around without joining. Put a stitch marker in the first stitch of every round and move it up as you go. The marker is your only sign of where a round starts.

Joined rounds

For flat motifs like the Sunflower, you join each round with a slip stitch to the first stitch. The pattern tells you when to join and when to chain up.

Closing a piece

- 1 Cut the yarn, leaving a tail about 6 inches (15 cm) long, and pull it through the last loop.
- 2 Thread the tail on a yarn needle and pass it through the front loop of each remaining stitch.
- 3 Pull tight to close the hole, take the needle inside the piece and bring it out somewhere hidden.
- 4 Cut the tail close to the fabric.

SECTION 7

Loops and spaces

Front loop, back loop and chain spaces.

The top of every stitch looks like a small V made of two loops. The loop closest to you is the **front loop** (FLO). The loop farthest from you is the **back loop** (BLO).

ABBREVIATION	MEANS	WHAT IT DOES TO YOUR WORK
FLO	Front loop only	Leaves a visible ridge at the back. Used for petals, skirts and flat edges.
BLO	Back loop only	Makes a ridge and a softer fold. Used for ribbing and turning a corner.
ch-sp	Chain space	Work under the chain, into the gap, not into the chain stitches.
st / sts	Stitch / stitches	One or more stitches in the row or round.

Tip

If you are unsure which loop you are in, look at the edge of the work after the round. The loop you skipped forms a small horizontal line.

SECTION 8

How to read a pattern line

Turn any line into work you can do.

Take this line from a toy pattern:

Rnd 4: (sc in next 2 st, inc) x 6 (24)

- 1 **Rnd 4** is the round number.
- 2 Everything inside the parentheses is one group: single crochet in each of the next 2 stitches, then one increase.
- 3 **x 6** means repeat that group 6 times.
- 4 **(24)** at the end is the total number of stitches you should have when the round is done. Count them.

A line like **Rnds 6-12: sc in each st around (30)** means you repeat that same round 7 times, and you should still have 30 stitches at every one.

Before you move to the next round

- ☐ The stitch count matches the number in parentheses.
- ☐ The stitch marker is in the first stitch of this round.
- ☐ You worked into every stitch, including the last one before the marker.

SECTION 9

Common mistakes and quick fixes

What goes wrong most often, and how to fix it.

WHAT YOU SEE	LIKELY CAUSE	FIX
The piece keeps getting bigger or smaller	Missing or extra stitches	Count every round. Undo back to the last round that matched the pattern.
The edges of a flat piece curve in	You skipped the last stitch of the row, or missed a turning chain	Count the stitches. The last stitch is often hidden in the turning chain.
The piece curls like a bowl	Too many increases or tight tension	Check the increase rounds. Try a hook one size larger.
Stuffing shows through the toy	Stitches are too loose	Use a smaller hook than the yarn label suggests.
The starting chain is too tight	Tight tension in the first row	Use a hook one or two sizes larger for the starting chain only.
You cannot find the first stitch of a round	No stitch marker	Put the marker in the first stitch of every round from now on.

Next step

Open CrochetLib from your access page, choose a Beginner pattern and use this guide beside you while you make your first rounds.